

It's something to think about. But even before we tell you that there do exist viruses for Linux, here's a snippet of what Scott Granneman of online computer security news portal SecurityFocus had to say about the issue, in 2003:

*"We've all heard it many times when a new Microsoft virus comes out. Someone on a mailing list or discussion forum complains about the latest in a long line of Microsoft email viruses or worms and recommends others consider Mac OS X or Linux as a somewhat safer computing platform. In response, another person says, basically, 'How ridiculous! The only reason Microsoft software is the target of so many viruses is because it is so widely used! Why, if Linux or Mac OS X was as popular as Windows, there would be just as many viruses written for those platforms!'*

*"Of course, it's not just 'regular folks' on mailing lists who share this opinion. Businesspeople have expressed similar attitudes... including ones who work for anti-virus companies. Jack Clarke, European product manager at McAfee, said, 'So we will be seeing more Linux viruses as the OS becomes more common and popular.'*

*"Mr. Clarke is wrong."*

Granneman goes on to explain why, but what he said reinforces the idea that Linux is inherently more secure, and that may be true. But we must also point out that there have been Linux security incidents involving viruses. In addition, there do exist Linux anti-virus tools.

It's a controversial subject. Ask a Linux aficionado and he'll tell you about file permissions and such, and how Linux users don't need to worry at all; ask someone marketing security products, and he'll tell you the urgency of the need to bolster Linux systems.

"Linux will be a target because its use is becoming more widespread," said Raimond Genes, European president for anti-virus at